

# Texas Fencing Academy

## We Make Champions

### First Steps as a Competitive Team Fencer

- [Pay USA Fencing annual competitive membership](#)
- [Pay TFA team annual fee](#)
- [Pay TFA Team Membership \(recurs monthly\)](#)
- [Complete TFA liability form and code of conduct](#)
- Buy TFA jacket and TFA t-shirt (see Coach Ray)
- Download TFA app (see Coach Ray)

### Equipment

Equipment can be ordered through TFA (then you don't pay shipping) or the following sites among others (where you'll pay shipping):

- [Blue Gauntlet](#) (TFA uses this vendor for starter gear)
- [Leon Paul](#) (TFA uses this vendor for advanced gear)
- [Absolute Fencing](#)

After five weeks of fencing, you should have purchased your own gear through TFA or one of these sites. This should include the following starter set:

- Jacket (sew TFA patch on upper part of back arm)
- Knickers
- Chest protector
- Plastron
- Mask
- Weapon
- Glove
- Bag

In order to be a competitive fencer, you will need to augment that gear with:

- Socks that cover the entire lower leg up to the knickers (at least two pairs)
- Fencing shoes (you may continue to use court shoes in the beginning but will need to talk to Coach Ray)
- 2nd electric weapon in your primary weapon choice
- 2 body cords (foil/sabre and epee use different body cords)
- 2 mask cords (foil/sabre)
- Lamé (foil and sabre use different lamés; epee does not use a lamé)
- FIE regulation sabre glove (sabre only)
- Foam padding for your chest protector if you use one in foil (chest protector is required for girls; you may need to purchase a whole new chest protector if yours can't be retrofitted to add the foam padding now required for foil)

- Mask (masks are weapon specific; if your starter mask is not the type for your chosen primary weapon then you will need to purchase the correct mask)
- Fencing bag (optional: you might consider upgrading to a wheeled bag)

To compete in national tournaments, fencers will need their last name on *either* their white jacket, foil lamé, and sabre lamé *or* the back leg of their knickers. It's a good idea to get it on your back leg that way no matter which weapon you fence your name will always be present. Fencers can have their name printed on clothes at any national tournament if they arrive a day early.

Blade size: Y10 uses size 2 blades or size 0 blades (ideally size 2 if the fencer can wield it). Y12 and higher divisions use size 5 blades. Younger fencers will thus need to buy new blades once they move up to Y12. Blades also have different weights and different degrees of "whippiness." Talk to Coach Ray about what is best for you.

Weapon grip: New fencers typically start with the French grip on epee and foil weapons. When strong enough, you'll switch to the pistol grip.

Competitive team fencers can keep their fencing bag at TFA.

## **Practice**

Saturday and Monday practices are workouts for competitive team fencers only. Tuesday, Wednesday, and Thursday practices have a workout in the first hour and open fencing after that. Team members should plan on three visits a week and at least five hours of training per week.

The [TFA workout and tournament schedule](#) lists practices, tournaments, and any days the club is closed for tournaments or holidays.

At the start of practice time, fencers should be dressed in shirt, shorts, fencing socks, and fencing shoes, with hair tied back. They'll put on knickers, chest protector, plastron, jacket, and lame after warmup.

Fencers should log their class, conditioning, and lesson time on the TFA app each day they're at the club.

## **Tournaments**

### *Selecting and Registering for Tournaments*

TFA has a calendar on the TFA app showing tournaments coming up in the year ahead. This includes TFA-designated tournaments (meaning TFA coaches will attend and TFA fencers are encouraged to compete), as well as other tournaments that coaches will not attend but that may still be good places for TFA fencers to compete. Local tournaments can be a good place for new competitive fencers to cut their teeth on tournaments, while regional and national tournaments offer increasing levels of competition. Talk to Coach Ray at the beginning of the year to identify the tournaments that are a good fit for your fencer's goals and experience.

Fencers must register themselves for tournaments. Register for national tournaments (e.g. SYC, NAC) and regional tournaments (e.g. RYC, RJCC, ROC) at [www.usafencing.org/all-events](http://www.usafencing.org/all-events). Register for local tournaments at <https://askfred.net>.

Tournaments will often have early-bird registration (discounted rates), regular registration (standard rates), and late registration (much higher rates), so it is beneficial to identify these deadlines early for the tournaments where your fencer would like to compete. There is typically an overall tournament registration fee, plus a fee for each event in which the fencer will compete. After a fencer has some tournament experience and wants to advance his/her skills, the fencer will often “fence up” in a higher age bracket to gain skills and experience.

For TFA-designated tournaments, when coaches travel to provide on-site coaching to the fencers, there will be a coaching fee. Coach Ray will divide this evenly between the fencers attending the tournament, and you can pay it through the TFA website after the tournament.

### *Qualifying for the National Championships*

There are various qualifying paths to the summer National Championships. These may change slightly year-to-year, so the best source for definitive information on this is in Chapter 2 of the [2019-20 USA Fencing Athlete Handbook](#). Here is also a great infographic on [qualifying paths to the 2019 summer nationals](#) for each age bracket.

There are qualifying paths through *national* points—obtained at events like the North American Cups (NACs) and Super Youth Circuit (SYC) tournaments—and qualifying paths through *regional* points—obtained at events like Regional Youth Circuit (RYC), Regional Junior Cadet Circuit (RJCC), and Regional Open Circuit (ROC) tournaments. You can factor this into which tournaments you select over the year leading up to summer nationals. You can [track your national and regional points and rankings](#). For regional points, we are in Region 5.

### *Before a Tournament*

Make sure you have registered and paid for the tournament and each event in which your fencer wants to compete. If you have not paid, your registration is not complete.

Make sure your fencer’s USA Fencing membership card is current (i.e. you have paid your USA Fencing annual membership fee that year). Ideally also make sure the USA Fencing card shows that your fencer’s age is “verified.” To do so, email a photocopy (scanned copy or picture from camera/phone) of your fencer’s birth certificate, passport, green card, driver’s license, or other legal document clearly showing date of birth and citizenship. Email documents to USA Fencing Membership Services at [information@usafencing.org](mailto:information@usafencing.org). Once your fencer’s birth date has been verified by USA Fencing, you do not need to do this again. The birth year verification will then be reflected on your fencer’s membership card. After you pay your annual membership fee, USA Fencing will mail you an updated membership card for a fee. Or to print a copy of the membership card, log into your [USA Fencing member profile](#) and select View Membership Card.

Have your equipment checked by the TFA armory before the tournament. Most fencers do this after their last practice before the tournament. You should have the TFA armory check all weapon-specific equipment for each weapon you'll be fencing at the tournament. Your fencer should learn how to test his/her own equipment, but the TFA armory is happy to check the equipment when he/she is starting out in the competitive program.

### *At a Tournament*

The following items are required for tournament check-in: (1) USA Fencing membership card, (2) fencer's ID document that verifies age, *only if* age is not yet shown as "verified" on the USA Fencing card (see tournament organizer's website to confirm the ID documents they will accept for age-verification purposes), and (3) any other items listed on the tournament organizer's website as being required for registration, such as a liability waiver that must be signed by a parent.

Other required items at tournaments are your TFA t-shirt and jacket, which TFA fencers should wear whenever they are not wearing their fencing gear. Optional items to consider bringing include: water bottle/Gatorade, energy bars/fruit/jerky/whatever your fencer likes to eat, hair brush and ponytail holders, band aids/first aid kit, safety pins, sewing kit including metal thread, mini screwdriver set, electrical tape, health insurance card, cash, and folding chairs.

Plan to get to the tournament at least one hour before the close of check-in for your first event and accomplish the following:

**STEP 1: EQUIPMENT CHECK.** Arrive at the venue *before* the opening of check-in for your event so your fencer can get his/her equipment checked *before* check-in starts, or you can go to the venue the night before to check equipment then as well. The tournament webpage will usually say when the armory will be open for equipment checks. When you arrive, the front desk will be able to tell you where the equipment check is located on site. When you present your cords to the armory for check-in, they should be neatly folded and have the check-in tags removed from prior tournaments. The armory will then check your equipment, tag your cords, and stamp your glove, lame, and mask.

**STEP 2: CHECK-IN.** Registration check-in opens one hour before the "check-in close" time listed for each event. Some tournaments list both the open and close times for check-in (e.g. the event will be listed in the tournament schedule as "Y10 Women's Epee 7:00-8:00am"). Other tournaments list only the check-in close time (e.g. the event will be listed in the tournament schedule as "Y10 Women's Epee 8:00am"). In both cases, this means that check-in opens at 7:00am, and that's when your fencer should check in. Your fencer cannot check-in after the close of check-in.

**STEP 3: WARM-UP.** After check-in, your fencer should stretch and do initial warm-up, then put on all clothes and cords needed for the event. He/she should then do informal warm-up bouts directed by other fencers, including fencing fencers from other clubs. At national events, sometimes it is necessary to 'claim' a strip and have all TFA fencers warm up there, as strips become harder to find.

**STEP 4: REPORT TO STRIP.** The tournament will announce information about your event either on monitors or on printouts posted in a designated spot on the wall. The first posting will appear before close of check-in, and it will list the fencers who have registered for the tournament, their seeding,

and who has checked in. The second posting will appear after close of check-in, and it will show the final list of who checked in. The third posting will list pools and strip assignments. The tournament will make an announcement when pools and strips are posted, so fencers need to pay attention to the announcements and report to their strips as soon as pools are posted.

**STEP 5: FENCE!** To know when your fencer will fence within his/her pool, you can take a photo of the director's pool list that shows each fencer's number and the order of the bouts. Your fencer should also be listening for the director's announcements of who is on strip and who is on deck. When your fencer is "on strip," that means he/she will fence right then. When he/she is "on deck," that means he/she will fence next, and he/she should stand by the strip. If a fencer is not yet on deck, he/she should be sitting down and watching opponents in the pool. Your fencer will fence each person in his/her pool. Once all bouts in that pool are done, each fencer will need to sign the scoresheet to confirm the results, and the director will turn this into the bout committee.

Once all pools in that event are done, the bout committee will post the new seeding, Direct Elimination (DE) pairings, and strip assignments on the monitors/printouts. DE pairings are done in brackets where the fencers with the highest and lowest rankings fence each other, moving in from there; for example, the fencers ranked 1 and 16 will fence each other, 2 and 15 will fence, 3 and 14, etc. Fencers should report to their strips as soon as DE assignments are posted. After each DE, fencers will need to sign the scoresheet, and the winner will turn it into the bout committee.

When your fencer is starting pools and when your fencer is going on deck in the DE, let Coach Ray know in person or in a phone call (not by text) so he can come coach. If more than one TFA fencer is fencing at the same time, in pools younger fencers have priority and he will spend more time with the younger kids since they need more coaching and older kids should know how to coach themselves. In DEs, older fencers have priority. DEs take precedence over pools if they're at the same time, as DEs are more important than pools and it's more important to have a coach at that time. Coach Ray will try to stand in middle and watch both, but he will mostly help the older fencer.

More on the various types of tournaments, tournament format, seeding, points, rankings, etc. is available in the [USA Fencing Athlete Handbook](#).

Out-of-town tournaments are a great time to visit as a team. We encourage evening team dinners or staying at the same hotel. Sometimes this isn't possible, but it is fun when it is!

As you have questions, don't hesitate to talk to other fencing parents! We have all navigated the (substantial!) complexity of getting a handle on tournament competition, and we are happy to help as you start the competitive fencing process. It is fun and rewarding for fencers and fencing families alike, and we look forward to working and cheering with you.

### *Useful Resources*

- [Determine events for which you are eligible](#)
- [Learn more about points](#)
- [Learn about qualifying paths to Summer Nationals](#)
- [Check your points and rankings](#)

- [Check if your USA Fencing membership is current](#)
- [Read the 2019-20 USA Fencing Rules](#)
- [Read the 2019-20 USA Fencing Athlete Handbook](#)
- [Read other USA Fencing tournament resources](#)
- [Learn how to become a referee](#)
- [Check your rating as a referee](#)
- [Find fencing clinics and camps](#)

### **TFA Club**

TFA is a non-profit club, and we welcome volunteers! There are many volunteer opportunities during the tournaments TFA organizes each year and also around the club throughout the year. Check with other parents and Coach Ray on how to plug in.

TFA hosts a summer party and winter holiday party each year, as well as periodic outings to movies or team dinners. These are great opportunities for the fencers and parents to get to know each other outside the club.